



Jaswinder Ahuja at a function with ex-President Dr APJ Abdul Kalam

timeframe. So, I was quite fascinated by these gizmos and that steered me toward electronics.”

In the counseling session after qualifying for the Common Entrance Examination for all IITs, Jaswinder preferred to take electronics in any of the IITs rather than opting for any other stream in the best-ranked IITs. It was a stressful situation for him as well as his family. His father requested the then Director of IIT Madras to counsel Jaswinder. However, Jaswinder did not change his mind. He explains, “I was passionate to understand and study the field of electronics and not anything else. Finally, I landed at the Indian Institute of Technology, Varanasi at Banaras Hindu University (IIT-BHU).”

Jaswinder recalls his engineering days as a “glorious period” of his life. He was an all-rounder. Besides studying, he was active in sports, dramatics, and painting. He joined National Cadet Corps (NCC) to continue shooting as a sport. BHU shooting team won the inter-university national championship under his captaincy. He was involved in various cultural activities, fests, dramatics, etc. His

passion for painting also flourished at IIT-BHU.

Jaswinder broke the stereotype of a good student repeatedly throughout his educational life. For example, he did not attend classes that were not interesting enough for him. He focused on overall development rather than scoring only good marks. He opines, “I learned important lessons in my life, on leadership, on teamwork, on facing and overcoming obstacles and challenges in dabbling with the unknown through my unique experiences during engineering days. Though these experiences were not always related to academics, as the academic system is quite well regimented in India thus leaving no scope for learning life lessons.”

He completed his bachelor’s degree in engineering in 1986. After that, he completed his master’s in computer engineering from Northeastern University in Boston, USA. This course exposed him to both

software and hardware engineering, especially robotics. He made a six-degree-of-freedom robotic arm as a part of his academic project. However, his passion for robotics was defeated by his determination to come back to India. He decided to continue with VLSI design as there was not much scope for robotics at that time.

Walking toward the professional goals

Soon after completing his master’s degree in 1988, Jaswinder began his professional journey. While describing the same, he narrates, “I was not sure if there were any jobs in VLSI design, either. A friend of mine showed me a job advertisement that was published in a newspaper called India Abroad. That advertisement was by a company named Gateway Design Automation, which had an office in Noida. They seemed to be doing some interesting work in VLSI design. That looked like an interesting opportunity to me for going back to India. I applied for the job at Gateway and they offered me a position. I had six months to join that company and I utilised those six months in learning VLSI design. In 1988, I came back and joined Gateway Design Automation.”

In 1989, Gateway Design Automation was acquired by Cadence Design Systems and Jaswinder has continued his journey in Cadence since then. While describing the initial days of his career, Jaswinder recalls, “It was a standard engineering job. I worked on various projects related to the development of building blocks for silicon chips,

“Either you do what you love, or you learn to love what you do. Because otherwise, your life is going to be miserable. If you get to do what you love, you are fortunate. But if it is not, you should try to enjoy it. I always try to make the most of everything because I don’t want to be miserable. I even approach most of my routine tasks with the mindset of doing them in interesting and novel ways.” — **Jaswinder Ahuja**